EXP-008: Digital Gold Market Research — Round 2 Analysis

Islamabad EasyPaisa & JazzCash Agents · Feb 21–22, 2026 · 18 Interviews

18 Interviews | Islamabad | EasyPaisa & JazzCash Agents | Analyzed by Terra

M Interview Method — Sequential Sentiment Funnel

WHO WE INTERVIEWED

EasyPaisa and JazzCash agents — these are small shopkeepers (grocery stores, mobile phone shops, general stores) who have a sticker on their door showing they're authorised agents for EasyPaisa or JazzCash, Pakistan's two dominant mobile money networks. Their day job is processing cash-in and cash-out for customers: someone walks in with Rs 5,000 cash, the agent transfers it digitally; someone else needs to withdraw, the agent hands them the cash. In return, they earn a small commission on every transaction.

We chose this group specifically because they **already sell digital financial services for commission**, already have a daily stream of customers doing money transactions, and are already comfortable operating a mobile app for financial products. If anyone could sell digital gold in Islamabad, it's them. **18 agents interviewed · Feb 21–22, 2026 · Across multiple areas of Islamabad**

WHAT CHANGED FROM ROUND 1

ROUND 1 PROBLEM	ROUND 2 FIX
Premium savings never mentioned	Led with: "Jewelers charge 5–6% extra — that's Rs 30,000–40,000 per tola. This app gives real market price"
Redemption was vague ("can come in physical form")	Said explicitly: "Buy and sell instantly — just hit a button. Want physical gold? Delivery from Dubai vault in about a week"
Fractional access unclear ("any amount")	Said: "Even Rs 500 buys real gold"
Tested dollars AND gold together	Gold-only pitch — dollars not mentioned at all
No sentiment tracking per section	Reaction captured after each part — this is how we measure what moves people
Trust barriers not addressed	Pitch proactively covers: vault location, instant transactions, physical delivery

SECTION 1 — BASELINE (1 minute)

Purpose: Understand if gold is already on their radar and if they know about jeweler markups.

Q1 "Gold has been everywhere lately — people around you have probably been talking about it, you've seen in the news the market has gone up. Have you been hearing more about gold recently?"

→ Wait for answer. Note their response. *Measures: is gold already in the shopkeeper's world, or are we introducing a concept they've never thought about?*

Q2 "Do you know how much extra a jeweler charges over the market price?"

→ Wait for answer. Most won't know the exact number — that's fine, it sets up the premium argument in Section 2. *Measures: markup awareness baseline.*

SECTION 2 — THE GOLD PITCH (2–3 minutes)

Purpose: Deliver the pitch in 3 parts. Pause after each part to capture the merchant's unfiltered reaction before moving on.

PART A — PRODUCT INTRODUCTION

> SAY: "Imagine real gold, on your phone. Stored in a secure vault in Dubai. You can buy as little as Rs 500 worth — and it's real gold, yours."

Q3 "What's your first reaction to that?"

→ Note their initial sentiment **before** you explain the economics. This is the baseline we compare Q4 against.

PART B — PREMIUM ECONOMICS ← THE KEY PART

> SAY: "Here's the thing about jewelers — they charge 5–6% over the real market price. On one tola, that's an extra Rs 30,000 to 40,000. With this app, you buy at the real price. No markup."

→ This is the most important moment. Watch their face. Did they lean in? Light up? Stay flat?

Q4 **"If your customers could skip that jeweler markup and get gold at real market price, would they be interested?"**

→ Did their sentiment *change* from Q3? This is our #1 metric. A merchant who was skeptical at Q3 but positive at Q4 = the economics argument worked. No change = it didn't move them. R2 result: 6/18 (33%) shifted positive — below the 50% threshold we needed.

PART C — INSTANT ACCESS + REDEMPTION

> SAY: "Buying and selling is instant — just hit a button. Want physical gold? Request delivery from the vault, it reaches you in about a week. Or you can sell anytime at market price."

Q5 "Does knowing you can buy and sell instantly — and get physical delivery — change how you feel about it?"

→ Note: did this resolve any "I need gold in my hands" concerns? In Round 1 this was the #1 barrier — 4 merchants raised it unprompted.

SECTION 3 — SHOPKEEPER BUY-IN (2 minutes)

Purpose: Find out if they would actually sell this product to their customers — like they do with EasyPaisa or JazzCash services.

Q6 "If you could earn commission selling this — like you do with EasyPaisa or JazzCash — would you?"

→ Note: Yes / Maybe / No. R2 result: 6/18 (33%) said yes — below the 40% threshold needed.

Q7 "What would you need to see before you'd feel comfortable selling this?"

→ Open-ended. Let them talk. Don't prompt — just listen and note everything. This is where barriers surface.

Q8 "Say a customer wants to buy gold for Rs 1,000. Could you tell them: 'This app gives you gold at a better price than the jeweler, and you can get it delivered whenever you want'?"

→ Note: would they feel confident making that pitch to a real customer? Can the merchant relay the value prop in their own words?

0 Executive Summary & Signal Matrix

RECOMMENDATION

ITERATE

What is this? ZAR is exploring whether it can expand from digital dollars into digital gold — gold that lives in a secure vault, bought and sold instantly through a mobile app. The question is whether EasyPaisa and JazzCash agents (the shopkeepers who already sell mobile money services for commission across Islamabad) would also sell digital gold to their customers. This is Round 2 of discovery research. Round 1 (14 shopkeepers, Rawalpindi) tested a vague concept. Round 2 tests a specific economic argument: jewelers charge 5–6% over the real gold price — that's Rs 30,000–40,000 extra per tola — and this app eliminates that markup entirely. We ran 18 interviews across Islamabad on February 21–22, 2026 to find out: does that savings argument move shopkeepers from skeptical to interested?

1 confirmed green (behavioral demand), 2 red (sentiment shift and distribution willingness both below threshold), 1 unknown (48-hour callback pending). The primary structural blocker is a trust deficit left by fraudulent investment apps — specifically a wave of scam apps from around 2012–2015 that promised high digital investment returns, collected millions of rupees from everyday people, and then collapsed. The memory

🟢

Behavioral Demand

Threshold: ≥3 merchants

4 / 18

● GREEN

🔴

Q4 Sentiment Shift

Threshold: ≥50%

33%

● RED

🔴

Distribution Willingness

Threshold: ≥40% (Q6=Yes)

33%

● RED

⚪

48h Callback

Threshold: ≥30% all 3 gates

Pending

● UNKNOWN

of those losses is still live in this community, and a pitch about "digital gold on an app" triggers that same pattern-match immediately.

The jeweler markup argument lands with merchants who already have markup awareness. It fails to move merchants who lack that baseline. The pitch needs an institutional anchor before Round 3.

Next action: Run 48h callback on all phone-number-givers. If ≥30% pass all 3 gates, upgrade to PROCEED. If <15%, design Round 3 with trust-resolution centerpiece.

1 Round 1 vs Round 2 Comparison

Round 1 — Rawalpindi (n=14)

Date	Feb 12, 2026
Preferred gold over dollars	4/14 (29%)
Positive sentiment	5/14 (36%)
Jeweler markup pitch tested	0/14 (0%)
Top barrier	Physical possession
#2 barrier	Trust/legitimacy

Round 2 — Islamabad (n=18)

Dates	Feb 21–22, 2026
Q4 positive shift	6/18 (33%)
Positive/excited	4/18 (22%)
Jeweler markup pitch tested	18/18 (100%)
Top barrier	Trust/scam app memory
#2 barrier	Physical possession

METRIC	R1	R2	DIRECTION
Sample size	14	18	↑ +4
Markup argument tested	No	Yes	↑ New
Excited/strongly positive	5/14 (36%)	4/18 (22%)	↓ −14pp
#1 barrier	Physical possession anxiety	Fraud/scam app memory	↕ Shifted
Behavioral signals observed	~2–3	4 confirmed	↑ Improved
Distribution willingness	Not tested	6/18 (33%)	↕ Baseline

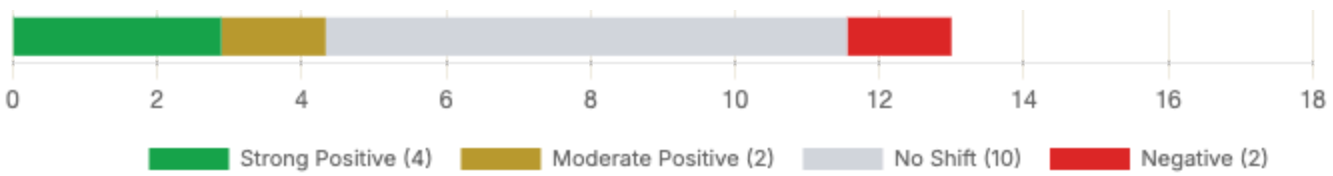
> Physical possession anxiety dropped from **#1 to #2**. Trust/legitimacy rose to **#1** — the redemption clarity pitch helped address the possession barrier, but exposed a deeper trust layer: community memory of fraudulent investment apps that collected people's money and disappeared. The markup argument alone cannot overcome that.

2 Q4 Sentiment Shift — Critical Metric

> **What is "Q4 shift"?** The interview delivers the pitch in stages. After Q3 (the merchant hears "real gold on your phone, Rs 500 minimum"), we record their gut reaction. Then we deliver the markup argument — "jewelers charge Rs 50–80K extra per tola; this app gives the real rate." Q4 asks: does that economics argument change their mind? A **"shifted"** merchant was neutral or skeptical at Q3, then said "yes, customers would be interested" at Q4. **"No shift"** means the markup argument didn't move them. This is the single most important metric: we're testing whether one specific economic argument can unlock merchant sentiment.

Q4 Reaction to Jeweler Markup Argument — did it move them? (n=18)

33% — BELOW 50% threshold



ID	OVERALL SEGMENT	Q3 BASELINE	Q4 SHIFT	KEY QUOTE / SIGNAL
R2-02	Excited	Positive — investment asset	Shifted ↑ Strong	*"I will buy from the app, not the market. I'm more interested in the app."*
R2-03	Skeptical	Positive concept, vague	No shift	*"No idea of this. Customer will come here."*
R2-04	Skeptical	Skeptical — concept unclear	No shift	*"It is difficult." (Q4 on customer interest)*
R2-05	Skeptical	50/50 on trust ("50-50 whether to trust")	No shift	*"Opinion on digital platforms is not good. Mostly such apps are made in vain."*
R2-06	Curious	Interested if rate differs	Moderate ↑	*"Buy one gram every month — that will be my investment and also my asset."*

ID	OVERALL SEGMENT	Q3 BASELINE	Q4 SHIFT	KEY QUOTE / SIGNAL
R2-07	Negative	Dismissive ("not there")	Shifted ↓ Neg	*"No, this is not our work. We only have what we have."*
R2-08	Excited	Interested — no major objection	Shifted ↑ Strong	*Willingly engaged through full pitch, would educate customers.*
R2-09	Curious	Never bought gold, open	Moderate ↑	*"Definitely should happen — if you save even 20–30K per tola, that's enough."*
R2-10	Excited	Very good — investment angle	Shifted ↑ Strong	*"Will tell customers, friends, and all family members."*
R2-11	Skeptical	No prior gold exposure	No shift	*"Is this illegal? Fraud is everywhere in Pakistan. I'll save myself."*
R2-12	Skeptical	Trust is prerequisite	No shift	*"If trust is built, many people will do it. No need to go to the market."*
R2-13	Excited	Very positive — Easy Money parallel	Shifted ↑ Strong	*"Every second person is on Easy Money. This will go forward, Insha Allah."*
R2-14	Negative	Skeptical — "invisible gold"	No shift	*"In Rs 500, that would be invisible gold. Physically, it won't be there."*
R2-15	Skeptical	Neutral, needs COD	No shift	*"Cash on delivery would be better. When goods reach customer, money moves."*
R2-16	Negative	Skeptical — scam app named	Blocked	*"Fraudulent investment apps came, people invested millions — it all collapsed. Without government approval, no."*
R2-17	Skeptical	Willing to experiment small	No shift	*"Take Rs 1,000 first, check it — if withdrawal is easy, trust builds."*
R2-18	Skeptical	Interested but distracted	No shift	*"One extra task disturbs us. One shop, one job. That's our experience."*
R2-19	Skeptical	Curious — CS student	No shift	*"Privacy and transaction security are two main things in building trust."*

Pattern: All 4 merchants who showed strong positive Q4 shift (R2-02, R2-08, R2-10, R2-13) had pre-existing markup awareness going into Q2/Q3. The argument only works when there's a cognitive anchor to hook onto. Merchants without markup awareness treat "jeweler charges extra" as an unverifiable claim.

3 Merchant Segments

⭐
Excited
22%

🔍
Curious
11%

⚖️
Skeptical
56%

✖
Negative
11%

R2-02, R2-08, R2-10, R2-13
4 merchants · Early adopter cluster

R2-06, R2-09
2 merchants · Investment-minded

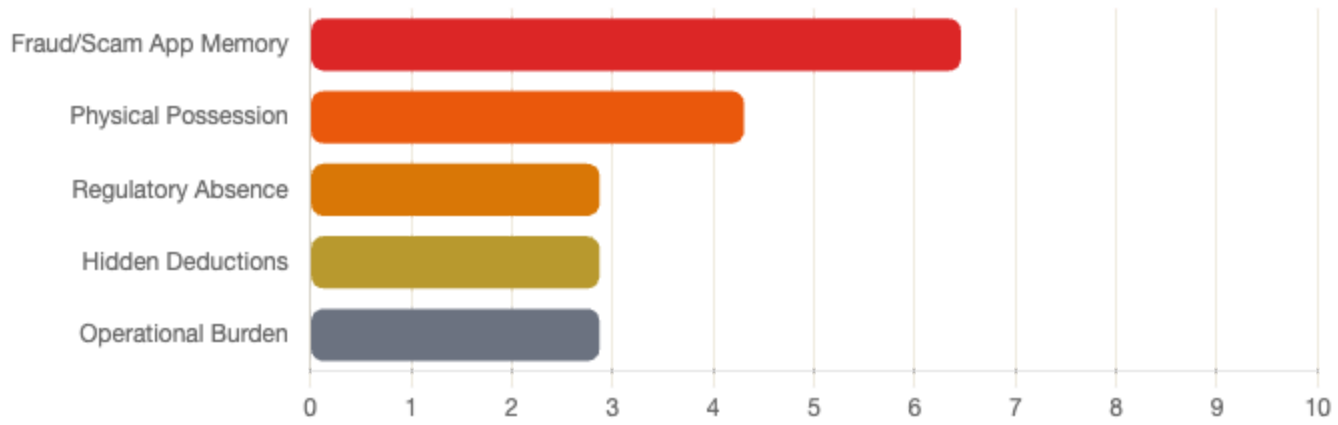
R2-03, R2-04, R2-05, R2-11, R2-12, R2-15, R2-17, R2-18, R2-19, +1
3 sub-archetypes: trust-first, operational, fraud-wary

R2-07, R2-14, R2-16
3 merchants · Hard blockers

Skeptical sub-archetypes: (1) *Trust-first* — need proof before engaging at all (R2-11, R2-12, R2-16); (2) *Operational-friction* — interested but one-job-per-shop constraint (R2-18); (3) *Incremental* — willing to experiment small and scale if verified (R2-05, R2-17, R2-19).

4 Top 5 Barriers

Barrier Frequency (out of 18 merchants)



#	BARRIER	FREQ	%	KEY QUOTE	ADDRESSABLE?
1	**Fraud/legitimacy — memory of scam investment apps**	9	50%	"Those investment apps came, people put in millions — it all collapsed. You can't just walk in and say digital." (R2-16)	**Partially** Needs institutional proof
2	**Physical possession anxiety**	6	33%	"That would be invisible gold. Physically, it won't be there." (R2-14)	**Yes** Vault cert + redemption demo
3	**Regulatory/government backing absent**	4	22%	"If government approves it, people will come. Without that — no." (R2-16)	**Partially** Legal clarity doc

#	BARRIER	FREQ	%	KEY QUOTE	ADDRESSABLE?
4	**Mechanics / hidden deductions**	4	22%	"If no deduction is taken, full money comes — that's the benefit." (R2-18)	**Yes** Explicit fee disclosure
5	**Operational burden / extra workload**	4	22%	"One shop, one job. That's our experience. Extra work disturbs us." (R2-18)	**Partially** Minimal-friction UX

R1→R2 barrier shift: Physical possession (#1 in Round 1) dropped to #2. Fraud/trust concerns rose to #1 — this was *unlocked* by Round 2's more specific pitch. When you go deeper on "real gold at market price," merchants surface the deeper trust debt left by fraudulent digital investment apps. This is progress: we found the actual blocker.

5 Behavioral Signals Tracker

4/18 — GREEN ✓ (threshold ≥3)

ACTION OBSERVED	MERCHANT	EVIDENCE	SIGNAL TYPE
Volunteered to buy through app unprompted	R2-02	"I will buy from the app, not the market. Will also check the price."	Purchase intent
Asked about launch date / current status	R2-09	Asked how intraday gold works, when app launches	Timing urgency
Compared to Easy Money — said "will go forward"	R2-10	"If app is launched and everything is as stated — very good." Would tell all family.	Referral intent
Drew Easy Money parallel independently; wanted WhatsApp	R2-13	"Every second person is on Easy Money. If trustable, no doubt — will buy and add." Noted R1 type questions unprompted.	Referral + distribute

Key pattern: All 4 behavioral signals came from the EXCITED segment. This is not random distribution — it's a tight early adopter cluster. These 4 are your evangelists. R2-13 is ready for a WhatsApp early-access group today.

6 Trust Infrastructure Gap

The Problem

→ 3+ merchants named fraudulent investment apps unprompted — this is community memory, not individual skepticism
→ Around 2012–2015, a wave of digital "investment" apps in Pakistan promised high returns, attracted millions of rupees from ordinary people, then collapsed or disappeared
→ The damage spread socially: neighbors told neighbors. An entire generation of small shopkeepers learned that "digital investment app" = scam
→ Any new "digital gold app" immediately triggers that same pattern-match, regardless of how it actually works

What Won't Work

→ More messaging or a better pitch deck
→ Additional features (won't help if foundation is absent)
→ "Vault in Dubai" framing — further away = less verifiable, not more secure
→ Enthusiasm from the ambassador
→ Small commissions as trust proxies

Required Trust Stack

→ Institutional anchor — named PK bank or regulated partner on screen
→ Regulatory clarity doc — SBP/SECP acknowledgement or legal brief
→ Physical proof — vault certificate, ideally with PK auditor
→ Community proof — existing merchants who used redemption (show, don't tell)

7 Terra's Field Coaching Notes

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1. **Name-check credibility before the markup pitch for skeptics**
Before delivering Section B with skeptical merchants, address the scam app pattern-match first — it operates silently and will block everything else. Interrupt it early. "Ye woh apps jaisi cheez nahi hai jo band ho gayi — yeh [partner bank] ke saath registered hai." This gives the markup argument something to land on.

2 **Easy Money bridge for EasyPaisa & JazzCash agents**
The Easy Money parallel is your strongest opening for this audience. R2-13 drew it independently — lean into it. Frame the product as: the gold version of what Easy Money did for cash transfers.
"Bilkul Easy Money ki tarah — lekin sona. Aapke phone mein, real gold."

3 **Fix the Rs 500 framing — use tola denominator**
R2-14's "invisible gold" objection reveals a real UX failure. Rs 500 sounds trivially small for gold — merchants can't mentally anchor it. Reframe: "You're building toward a tola — Rs 500 is your first step, without the jeweler's overhead." The tola is the unit they understand.

4 **R2-14 is your product brief**
R2-14 gave the clearest feature checklist of any merchant: (1) show quantity in grams explicitly, (2) show live market rate, (3) transparent margin/fee before purchase, (4) clear delivery timeline. Build this into the onboarding flow. If R2-14 is not confused, no merchant will be.

5 **4 evangelists are ready — activate today**
R2-02, R2-08, R2-10, R2-13 showed unprompted demand. Create the WhatsApp early-access group today and add these 4 first. Their referral behaviour will be the cheapest Round 3 recruiting tool you have. Don't let momentum cool.

8 Key Quotes Gallery

"

I will buy from the app, not the market. I'm more interested in the app. Because everything is happening online — if it becomes safe and secure, it's much better.

R2-02 Excited Q4 — Markup Argument

"

Every second person is on Easy Money. There's no phone without it. Insha Allah, this will also go forward. If it's a trustable app, there's no doubt — will buy and recommend.

R2-13 Excited Q3–Q4

"

I will tell my customers. I will tell my friends. I will tell everyone in my family. I will also agree — it is a good thing that a person can carry.

R2-10 Excited Q6 Distribution

"

If it is real then — 100% we will buy it. Now there are so many customers on Easy Money. On this also, Insha Allah will take us forward again.

R2-13 Excited Q3 First Reaction

"

In Rs 500, what gold will be there? That would be invisible gold. Physically, there will not be gold there. Until a person sees something in front of his eyes, he doesn't trust it.

R2-14 Negative Q3 First Reaction

"

Those apps came. People invested at high percentage returns. The app closed. Millions and crores went. Without government approval — I cannot recommend this to anyone.

R2-16 Negative Q5 Trust

"

Is this illegal or legal? In Pakistan, fraud is happening. A person who has a little album will save himself. He won't do it without understanding.

R2-11 Skeptical Q7 Barriers

"

Take Rs 1,000 first. Check it — if withdrawal is easy, there's no hurdle, the person's trust will build. Then step by step, Rs 10,000, Rs 1 lakh. It's all about reliability and easy access.

R2-17 Skeptical Q3 First Reaction

"

If you save even 20–30K per tola, that's enough. Definitely should happen. [Unprompted:] If there is a notice or banner so customers can see there's such an option in this shop — I'd guide everyone.

R2-09 Curious Structural Insight

"

Buy one gram from the app every month. I can't afford a full tola now — but 10 months of Rs 500–1,000 and that's my investment and my asset. That's the idea that gives more value.

R2-06 Curious Structural Insight — Fractional

9 Recommendation & Next Steps

CURRENT RECOMMENDATION

ITERATE

1 of 4 signals green. Trust infrastructure is the structural blocker — the jeweler markup argument is a real value prop that lands with merchants who have markup awareness, but it cannot

overcome the community-memory of collapsed investment apps alone. The product needs an institutional anchor before another round of interviews.

✅ If callback strong (>30%)

- Upgrade to PROCEED
- Initiate product scoping sprint
- Identify vault partner (preferably PK-based or PK-audited)
- Model commission economics (target 1–3% on sale)
- Prepare SBP/SECP regulatory brief
- Activate 4 evangelists as beta testers

⚠️ If callback weak (<15%)

- Remain ITERATE
- Design Round 3 with trust-resolution centerpiece
- Source institutional anchor before field work
- Add vault certificate to physical pitch materials
- Reframe Rs 500 → tola-building framing
- Add Easy Money bridge explicitly to script

Feed-forward → EXP-008 Round 3: Trust-resolved pitch with (1) named institutional anchor + (2) vault certificate physical artifact + (3) Easy Money framing + (4) community proof from existing redemptions. Target n=20 fresh Islamabad zones, different areas from Feb 21–22 routes (G-10/11, E-7/E-8, Sector I-8/I-9 markets).